remained on the sidelines and accepted Hamid Karzai's rise (as part of the CIA-led Pashtun rebellion in the Taliban's stronghold in south Afghanistan).[138] Samajwadi Party leader Janeshwar Mishra's prognosis that whoever came to power in Kabul would be the American *Mahaprabhu's* (Great Lord) man came true at Bonn. Satinder Lambah, Vajpayee's special envoy to Afghanistan and Pakistan, was dispatched to Bonn (soon after he opened India's embassy in Kabul in November 2001). The Rome Group, the Cyprus Group, the Peshawar Group, and the UF, represented different Afghan stakeholders.[139]

Former King Zahir Shah, a Durrani Pashtun, headed the Rome Group. The Cyprus Group was close to Iran, and the Peshawar Group mostly represented the Gailani family known for its secular royalist credentials.[140] The UF that was led by Yunus Qanooni, had Russia, Iran, and India's support. Missing from the conference were Pashtun Islamists such as Hizb-e-Islami (Hekmatyar), Hizb-e-Islami (Khalis), the Haqqanis, Abdul Rasul Sayyaf of the Ittehad-i-Islami, the Taliban, and Afghanistan's urban elite that had not taken sides during the civil war. Islamabad sent Arif Ayub, Pakistan's former ambassador to the Taliban, and Farooq Afzai, an ISI officer.[141] Afzai's Indian counterpart, X, had also flown to Bonn and was booked into a hotel near Guesthouse Petersberg (where the conference was happening) and maintained covert communication channels with the different Afghan factions.[142] Dobbins represented the US, Zamir Kabulov represented Moscow, Robert Cooper represented the UK, and Iran sent senior diplomat and Foreign Minister Javad Zarif. Close to the UF, and actively engaging with the Rome Group, Lambah argues that India played an important role at Bonn for two reasons.[143]

Firstly, India, along with Iran and Russia was crucial in negotiating a settlement between different Afghan factions, Lambah claims.[144] The conference had run into a deadlock when Qanooni refused to give key ministerial berths and 75 per cent parliamentary representation to Karzai and other Pashtun groups.[145] Lambah, along with Kabulov and Zarif and other top diplomats, tried convincing Qanooni at a midnight meeting in Brahimi's room to make the concessions, whereas X convinced Haji Qadir and the Rome Group 'to strike the deal with Karzai and the UF for the sake of Afghanistan'.[146] In the end, eleven of twenty-nine berths in the provisional Cabinet went to Pashtun candidates.[147] Secondly,